

FREE DOWNLOAD

The Senior *Makeup Guide.*

*Look like yourself.
On your absolute best day.*

Skin prep — starting now.

Foundation & base for natural light.

The SPF flashback problem — and how to avoid it.

Eyes, brows, lips & blush done right.

DIY vs. professional — how to decide.

Touch-up kit for Texas heat.

What to practice before session day.

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WELCOME

The Goal Is Not to Look Like Someone Else.

"The goal is to look like the most polished version of you — in a way that still feels like you in ten years."

WHAT YOU'LL LEARN

- Skin prep that shows on camera
- Foundation that doesn't flashback
- Eyes, brows & lips done right
- How to touch up in Texas heat
- DIY vs. professional MUA

Camera lenses are honest. They read every detail — the unblended edge, the shine, the lip color that disappears. This guide gives you everything you need to show up camera-ready and completely yourself.

Whether you plan to do your own makeup or work with a professional, these are the principles that matter most: skin-first preparation, finishes that work on camera, and choices that hold up through a full session in Austin heat.

Read it once. Practice your look at least twice before session day. Then show up glowing.

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NP SENIORS — ALL-INCLUSIVE

Hair & makeup included.

You show up.

Professional styling handled from start to finish.

01

Skin Prep.

The best makeup starts with the best possible canvas. Good skin on session day isn't luck — it's what you do in the week before. These steps make a visible difference on camera.

ONE WEEK BEFORE

- + Start drinking more water than usual — hydration shows on camera
- + Exfoliate gently 2–3 times (not the night before — too close)
- + Avoid trying new skincare products — reactions show clearly on camera
- + Begin moisturizing morning and night, every day
- + Avoid salty foods that cause puffiness
- + Get on a reasonable sleep schedule — dark circles are real

THREE DAYS BEFORE

- + Do a full makeup trial run in natural light
- + Take test selfies with your phone flash — check for flashback
- + Confirm your foundation shade still matches your skin
- + Hydrate deeply — drink water, use a hydrating mask
- + Avoid alcohol — it dehydrates skin and causes puffiness
- + Avoid picking, popping, or any aggressive skin treatments

THE NIGHT BEFORE

- + Double-cleanse and apply a rich moisturizer
- + Apply any serums you normally use — skip new ones
- + Lay out all makeup in session order
- + Charge your phone — you'll want touch-up selfies on the day
- + Get 7–8 hours of sleep — no exceptions
- + Do NOT exfoliate or use retinol — both cause sensitivity

MORNING OF

- + Cleanse with a gentle, non-stripping cleanser
- + Apply moisturizer and let it absorb 10–15 min before primer
- + Apply makeup in natural light if possible
- + Set with setting spray — not just powder
- + Pack your touch-up kit (details on the last page)
- + Take a phone selfie with flash before you leave — a quick check

PRO TIP: TEST WITH FLASH BEFORE SESSION DAY

Apply your full makeup look and take a selfie with your phone flash. If your face looks ghostly white — especially around the nose and under eyes — you have a flashback problem. See page 05 for the fix.

02

Foundation & Base.

Camera lenses flatten features slightly — your everyday foundation may read washed out in photos. The goal is medium-to-full coverage with a matte or satin finish. Not cakey. Not shiny. Polished.

PRIMER & FOUNDATION

- + **Always start with primer.**
Primer fills pores, extends wear, and gives foundation something to grip. Apply and let it set for 2–3 minutes before foundation. This one step extends your makeup by hours in Texas heat.
- + **Build coverage — go slightly heavier than everyday.**
Cameras read makeup lighter than the human eye does. What feels like 'too much' in your mirror will look perfectly balanced on camera. Build coverage where you need it.
- + **Satin or matte finish — not dewy.**
Dewy foundations catch and reflect light unevenly on camera, creating shine that looks greasy rather than glowing. Satin gives healthy-looking skin without the problem. Matte works beautifully if you set with a light hand.
- + **Blend down your neck.**
One of the most common issues in senior portraits — a visible foundation line at the jawline. Blend your foundation down to your neck and collarbone so everything reads as one even tone on camera.

CONCEALER & SETTING

- + **Concealer: apply generously and blend completely.**
Under-eye circles, redness, and blemishes are amplified by lenses. Use a shade 1–2 tones lighter under the eyes for a natural brightening effect — not dramatically lighter, which causes flashback.
- + **Color correct before concealing.**
Green concealer for redness and blemishes. Peach or orange for dark circles on medium-to-deep skin tones. Apply before your regular concealer, blend completely, then layer on top.
- + **Pigmented setting powder — never translucent.**
Translucent setting powders can cause flashback. Use a powder with pigment that matches your skin. Apply with a damp sponge rather than a brush to avoid a powdery finish.
- + **Setting spray is non-negotiable.**
A good setting spray melts all your layers together into one cohesive skin finish and adds hours of wear. Apply as the final step. This is especially critical for Austin outdoor sessions.

FINISH COMPARISON — WHAT EACH LOOKS LIKE ON CAMERA

MATTE

No shine, no reflection. Long-wearing. Slightly flattens texture. Best choice for oily skin or very bright outdoor light.

SATIN

Soft natural glow without shine. Most flattering finish for camera work. Works for most skin types in natural light.

DEWY

Healthy-looking radiance — but catches and reflects light unevenly on camera. Use only with a matte setting powder on top.

GLOWY/LUMINOUS

Creates hot spots and shine in photos. Avoid as a base finish. Small highlight in specific spots is fine — full-face luminous is not.

03

Eyes & Brows.

Eyes are the focal point of every portrait. They also disappear on camera faster than anywhere else. Go bolder than you think — what feels heavy in your mirror reads natural through a lens.

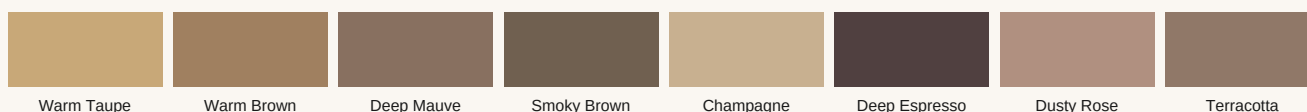
EYES

- + **Go about 30% heavier than your everyday look.**
Flash and natural light both wash out eyeshadow depth and liner definition. What looks bold in the mirror reads balanced through the lens. Blend well — camera picks up harsh edges immediately.
- + **Tight-line your upper lash line.**
Drawing liner along the waterline of your upper lashes creates the illusion of fuller lashes without a visible liner line. One of the highest-impact, lowest-effort moves you can make.
- + **Define both top and bottom lashes.**
Apply mascara to both upper and lower lashes. The lower lash line frames the eye on camera. Use waterproof formula for outdoor sessions.
- + **Eyeshadow: matte base, subtle shimmer on the lid only.**
Warm taupes, soft browns, muted mauves photograph beautifully. Avoid glitter — it scatters flash unpredictably. A small shimmer on the center lid is lovely. A full glitter lid is not.
- + **False lashes — worth considering.**
Natural lashes can disappear on camera. Individual clusters or a half-lash on the outer corners photograph more naturally than a full strip. Practice applying before session day.

BROWS

- + **Brows frame the entire face — fill them every time.**
Well-defined brows add structure, expression, and clarity to every portrait. Even if you have naturally full brows, fill sparse areas and define the shape. Cameras flatten features — defined brows fight back.
- + **Use small, feathery strokes for a natural finish.**
Heavy, drawn-on brows look harsh in print. Use an angled brush with a powder or pencil that matches your hair color. Light, hairlike strokes in the direction of growth read as natural on camera.
- + **Set with brow gel.**
Brows move throughout a session — wind, sweat, expression. A clear or tinted brow gel keeps everything in place from start to finish. Non-negotiable for outdoor Austin sessions.
- + **Don't over-darken.**
Brows that are significantly darker than your hair color read as drawn-on in print. Match as closely as possible to your natural hair color — go one shade darker at most.

EYESHADOW COLORS THAT PHOTOGRAPH WELL IN NATURAL LIGHT



04

Lips, Blush & Contour.

These three elements add warmth, dimension, and life to your face on camera. Without them, even a flawless base can read flat. With them, your natural features come through the lens with clarity.

L I P S

- + **Never go lighter than your natural lip color.**
Very light nudes wash out completely on camera. Always go at least one shade deeper — what looks slightly bold in the mirror reads natural through a lens.
- + **Lip liner is the secret to lasting color.**
Fill your entire lip with liner first, then apply lipstick on top. This base holds color significantly longer — especially through outfit changes and outdoor heat.
- + **Matte or satin finish — not gloss.**
Heavy gloss creates hot spots in natural light and reflects flash unpredictably. A tiny touch of gloss at the center of the lower lip is fine. Full-lip gloss is not.
- + **What photographs beautifully.**
Nudes one shade deeper than your skin, soft pinks, berries, warm reds, muted mauves, terracotta. Avoid very light nudes and overly bright orange-reds.
- + **Reapplication plan.**
Bring your lip liner and lipstick for touch-ups between looks. Using liner as a base first means you only need to touch up the surface, not rebuild from scratch.

B L U S H & C O N T O U R

- + **Blush is non-negotiable.**
Camera light flattens natural flush. Without blush you will look washed out even with a full face of makeup. Apply to the apples of the cheeks and blend upward. Rosy and peachy tones work for most skin tones.
- + **Warm, well-blended blush — never too much.**
Blend until you think it's gone, then check. What looks subtle in your mirror reads well on camera. Build slowly — it's much easier to add than to remove.
- + **Contour for structure, not drama.**
A matte bronzer along the cheekbones, sides of the nose, and jawline adds definition cameras would otherwise flatten. Keep it soft — you want structure, not shadow.
- + **Highlighter: satin only, right places only.**
A satin highlighter on the tops of the cheekbones, the brow bone, and Cupid's bow adds a natural glow. Avoid the nose bridge and forehead — they reflect light on their own.
- + **Avoid glittery bronzer or shimmer blush.**
These reflect flash unpredictably. Choose matte or finely satin-finish versions for any session involving flash or direct sun.

L I P C O L O R S T H A T P H O T O G R A P H W E L L



Terracotta

Berry Rose

Warm Red

Dusty Pink

Muted Mauve

Brick Nude

Peach Nude

Deep Berry

05

The SPF Flashback Problem.

This is the most common makeup mistake in senior portrait photography — and the easiest to fix once you know about it. Read this section carefully before you buy anything.

WHAT IS FLASHBACK?

Flashback is the white cast that appears on your face in photos — especially around the nose and under the eyes. It makes you look ghostly and uneven, even if your makeup looked perfect in the mirror. It happens when certain ingredients reflect the camera's flash or bright natural light back at the lens.

THE CULPRITS — AVOID THESE INGREDIENTS

Zinc oxide · Titanium dioxide · Silica · SPF above 15 in foundation or powder

These are the light-reflecting ingredients in physical sunscreens. They bounce light — including camera flash. Check ingredient lists before you buy.

HOW TO AVOID IT

- + **Use SPF-free foundation.**
Choose foundation with no SPF, or SPF 10 or below. Good options: NARS Sheer Glow, Make Up For Ever HD Skin, Maybelline Fit Me, L'Oréal Infallible. Apply your SPF moisturizer underneath and let it absorb before foundation.
- + **Use a pigmented setting powder — never translucent.**
Translucent powders are the biggest flashback culprits. Use a finely milled pigmented powder that matches your skin tone. Apply with a damp sponge to avoid a powdery finish.
- + **Apply SPF moisturizer, let it absorb, then build on top.**
Apply SPF moisturizer, wait 10–15 minutes for full absorption, then apply primer and foundation. This sequence minimizes flashback significantly.
- + **Test with your phone flash before session day.**
After your full makeup trial, take a selfie with your phone flash on. If your face looks significantly lighter than your neck — especially around the nose — you have a flashback issue. Adjust before session day.
- + **If you use SPF foundation, set with a tinted powder.**
A pigmented powder in your shade applied on top of an SPF foundation can neutralize some flashback. Switching to SPF-free foundation is the better fix — but this helps in a pinch.
- + **Choose chemical SPF, not physical.**
Chemical sunscreens absorb UV rays rather than reflecting them. They don't cause flashback. Physical sunscreens (zinc, titanium) reflect everything — including your photographer's flash.

We shoot with both natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors. These guidelines apply to every session regardless of location or time of day.

06

DIY vs. Professional.

There is no wrong answer here. The best choice is the one that makes you feel most like yourself when you walk through the door. Here's what to consider.

NP SENIORS 2027 · ALL-INCLUSIVE EXPERIENCE

Professional hair, makeup & styling included — fully, completely, no add-ons.

You show up. We take care of the rest. Every detail handled.

DO IT YOURSELF

Best if:

- + You have a makeup routine you love and wear daily
- + You want to look like a more polished version of yourself
- + You feel most confident doing your own makeup
- + You have time to practice at least twice before session day

Key requirement:

Practice your full look in natural light and take a selfie with flash at least twice before session day.

PROFESSIONAL MUA

Best if:

- + Makeup is not your comfort zone
- + You want to experiment with a polished elevated look
- + You have multiple outfit looks requiring different makeup vibes
- + You want to relax and be taken care of on session day

Key requirement:

Book an MUA with photography experience. Ask to see outdoor natural light work. Bring reference photos.

IF YOU HIRE A PRO — TIPS FOR THE APPOINTMENT

- + **Bring reference photos.**
Show your MUA specific images of the look you want — skin finish, eye definition, lip color. Words like 'natural' mean different things to different people.
- + **Tell them you're shooting in outdoor natural light.**
This matters for product selection — especially foundation finish and SPF ingredients. A good MUA will adjust their approach accordingly.
- + **Book a trial run 1–2 weeks before.**
A trial lets you see the look on camera before session day. Take photos in natural light and with flash. Adjust anything that isn't working.
- + **Bring your touch-up essentials.**
Even with professional application, you'll touch up lips and powder between looks. The MUA handles the start. You handle maintenance through the session.

07

Touch-Up Kit & Session Day.

A well-packed touch-up kit takes five minutes to assemble and saves your makeup through a full session. Here's exactly what to bring — and how to use it between looks.

THE ESSENTIAL KIT

- + Blotting papers — use before powder, not instead of
- + Setting powder in your shade + small brush
- + Setting spray — spritz to refresh, not rebuild
- + Lip liner and lipstick — for every outfit change
- + Concealer for any blemish touch-ups
- + Travel-size mascara (waterproof)
- + Small powder brush + blending sponge
- + Brow gel for flyaways

BONUS FOR AUSTIN SESSIONS

- + Blotting papers — bring twice as many as you think
- + Thermal setting spray — holds makeup through Texas heat
- + Portable fan (small, battery-operated) — game changer
- + Travel hairspray and bobby pins
- + Oil-absorbing sheets (different from blotting papers)
- + Waterproof everything — eyes, brows, lips
- + A small facial mist for refreshing between looks
- + Sunscreen for your décolleté between shots

HOW TO TOUCH UP BETWEEN LOOKS — IN ORDER

- + **01 Blot first — don't add powder to shine.**
Press blotting papers gently to absorb oil and shine before reaching for powder. Adding powder on top of oil creates a cakey, uneven buildup that looks worse on camera.
- + **03 Refresh with setting spray.**
A quick spritz of setting spray after powder melts everything back together and removes the powdery look. This is the step most people skip — and it makes the biggest difference.
- + **05 Quick check in natural light before the next look.**
Step outside or near a window. Take a quick selfie. Check for anything that needs adjusting before we call you back for the next setup.
- + **02 Set with targeted powder — T-zone and forehead only.**
You don't need to re-powder your whole face. Focus only on the areas that have gotten shiny. Use a light hand and a fluffy brush. Less is more.
- + **04 Rebuild lips from the liner base.**
Apply liner first, then lipstick on top. Because you filled your lip with liner at the start, touch-ups take 20 seconds and look as fresh as the original application.

"The clients who walk away with images they love showed up knowing what they wanted, prepared enough to feel confident, and present enough to let the moments happen."

About Nydam Photography.

We have been photographing Austin families, seniors, couples, and milestones since 2008. Every session we do is personal. We arrive prepared — every session planned with intention — and we create something real.

We photograph with natural light and flash — almost always, even outdoors — because the quality of the image matters more than the convenience of the approach. Every image is considered. Every detail is intentional.

GENUINE

Every portrait should feel like you — not a polished version of someone else. We create the conditions for real moments, then capture them.

INTENTIONAL

Light, posing, expression, timing — every element of a great portrait is considered in advance and guided with care throughout.

TIMELESS

We edit for longevity, not for trends. The images we create together are meant to stop you in your tracks ten years from now.

Weddings · Families & Portraits · Seniors · Sacraments · Quinceañeras · Events · Sports · Corporate Headshots & Branding
Every specialty. One standard of care.

KNOW SOMEONE WHO DESERVES THIS?

Pass this guide along — or send them directly to us.

The right photographer changes everything. If you found yours — share that gift.

A referral from a client is the highest compliment we receive.

With warmth,

Arlen and Tanya Nydam, Nydam Photography

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